

Lab 4: Build Your Own Skill

Time: 15 minutes
What you need: Claude.ai (web interface)
Prerequisite: Prompts from Labs 1-3

The Goal

Take the best prompt you wrote today and turn it into a reusable Skill. Tomorrow morning, you'll activate it with one click instead of rewriting the prompt from scratch.

Part 1: Choose Your Prompt (2 min)

Look back at your work from today. Which prompt produced the most useful output for your actual job?

Good candidates:

From Lab	Prompt Type	Skill It Becomes
Lab 1	GOLDEN framework email	Email Tone & Format Skill
Lab 1	Report creation prompt	Report Formatter Skill
Lab 2	Project instructions	Project Template Skill
Lab 3	Data analysis prompt	Analysis Framework Skill
Lab 3	Battle card prompt	Competitive Intel Skill

Pick one. Write it here:

My chosen prompt:

What it does:

Part 2: Create the Skill (5 min)

Method A: Create with Claude (Recommended for First Skill)

1. Go to **Settings → Skills → New Skill**
2. Choose "**Create with Claude**"
3. Describe what you want in plain English. Example:

"I need a skill that takes raw meeting notes and produces a formatted follow-up email. The email should have: a thank-you opening, 3-5 key decisions listed as bullets, action items with owners and deadlines, and a professional closing. Tone should be warm but concise. Keep it under 200 words."

1. Claude will ask clarifying questions — answer them
2. Review the generated instructions
3. Click **Save**

Method B: Write Instructions (For Simple Skills)

1. Go to **Settings → Skills → New Skill**
2. Choose "**Write skill instructions**"
3. Write your rules in plain English:

When I give you raw data or bullet points, create a formatted weekly status report with these sections:

1. Executive Summary (2-3 sentences)
2. Key Metrics (table format, include % change)
3. Wins This Week (3-5 bullets)
4. Risks & Blockers (flag with severity: □□□)
5. Next Week's Priorities (numbered list)

Rules:

- Keep total length under 1 page
- Use professional but direct tone
- Always end with "Recommended Actions"
- Bold the most important metric
- If data is missing, flag it – don't guess

1. Give your Skill a clear name (e.g., "Weekly Status Report")
 2. Click **Save**
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Part 3: Test Your Skill (5 min)

This is the critical step. A Skill that hasn't been tested is just a wish.

1. **Open a brand new chat** (don't use your existing conversation)
2. Click the **+** menu at the bottom
3. Find your Skill and **activate it**
4. Give it **fresh input** — different from what you used in the lab

Test Checklist

Run through these checks:

Check	☐ or x
Does it follow your format instructions?	
Is the tone right?	
Is the length appropriate?	
Did it include all required sections?	
Would you send this to your boss as-is?	

If Something's Off

Don't start over. Edit the Skill:

1. Go to **Settings → Skills**
2. Click your Skill
3. **Edit the instructions** — be more specific about what went wrong
4. Test again

Common fixes: - Output too long → Add "Keep total response under 300 words"
- Wrong tone → Add "Write as a senior manager, not a junior analyst" - Missing sections → List them explicitly with "Always include:" - Too generic → Add "Use specific numbers from the input data"

Part 4: Refine & Share (3 min)

Make It Bulletproof

Add these to your Skill instructions if they're not already there:

- **Input format:** "I will provide [raw notes / CSV data / bullet points]"
- **Output format:** "Create a [report / email / brief] with these sections:"
- **Constraints:** "Maximum [X] words. [Professional/casual] tone."
- **Edge cases:** "If information is missing, note it as [TBD] — do not fabricate"
- **Audience:** "This will be read by [VP / client / team members]"

Share It

Want your team to use the same Skill?

1. Go to **Settings → Skills**
2. Click your Skill → **Export**
3. Share the .md or .zip file via email or Slack
4. Colleagues import via **New Skill → Upload a Skill**

Starter Templates

If you're stuck, copy one of these into "Write skill instructions" and customize:

Template 1: Email Formatter

Transform my rough notes into a professional email.

Format:

- Subject line (clear, actionable)
- Opening (1 sentence, context-setting)
- Body (2-3 short paragraphs, key points bolded)
- Closing (clear next step or ask)

Rules:

- Match my tone from Personal Preferences
- Keep under 150 words
- No filler phrases ("I hope this finds you well")
- End with a specific call to action

Template 2: Meeting Notes → Action Items

Convert raw meeting notes into a structured summary.

Sections:

1. Meeting Summary (2-3 sentences)
2. Key Decisions (bullet list)
3. Action Items (table: Task | Owner | Deadline)
4. Open Questions (anything unresolved)
5. Next Meeting Agenda Items

Rules:

- Extract action items even if not explicitly stated
- If no deadline mentioned, flag as "TBD – needs deadline"
- Bold any blockers or escalation items
- Keep summary factual, not interpretive

Template 3: Data Analysis Brief

Analyze the data I provide using all five levels:

1. Descriptive: What happened? (key metrics, totals)
2. Diagnostic: Why? (root causes, correlations)
3. Predictive: What will likely happen next?
4. Prescriptive: What should we do about it?
5. Patterns: What non-obvious trends exist?

Format as an executive brief. Use specific numbers from the data – never approximate. If you can't calculate something, say so.

End with "3 Questions Your CFO Will Ask" and suggested answers.

What You Built

In 15 minutes, you created: - ☐ A reusable Skill from your best prompt today - ☐ Tested it with fresh input - ☐ Refined the instructions based on output quality - ☐ A shareable asset your team can use

This is the multiplier. Every hour you spent learning prompting today just got packaged into a one-click tool you'll use for months.

Key Takeaways

1. **If you've written a prompt 3+ times, make it a Skill**

2. **"Create with Claude" is the fastest way to start** — let Claude interview you
3. **Test with fresh input** — not the same data you built it with
4. **Share with your team** — one person's great prompt becomes everyone's tool
5. **Iterate** — the best Skills go through 3-4 revisions

Next up: Lab 5 — Executive Briefing Challenge (your capstone exercise)
